

Scaling a UK Beauty & Skincare Brand on TikTok Shop

From an Underperforming Account to a 13.10x ROI Growth Engine via TikTok Shop GMV Max

Industry: Beauty & Skincare
Target Market: United Kingdom
Platform TikTok Shop
Campaign Type TikTok Shop GMV Max
Primary Objective: Increase GMV, scale order volume, and maximize ROI
Campaign Period: December 2025 – June 2026
My Role: Paid Media Strategist - full account audit, product strategy, creative direction, and campaign optimization



Executive Summary

When I took over this account, the client was already advertising on TikTok Shop - but the campaign wasn't producing enough purchase data for TikTok's algorithm to optimize with confidence. Product selection was scattered, the creative library was thin, and conversion signals were too weak to support scaling.

Rather than pushing more budget into a weak foundation, I rebuilt the account from the ground up: sharper product prioritization, a stronger and more diverse creative library, and a disciplined, signal-first optimization process built around TikTok Shop's GMV Max engine.

The Business Challenge

The client had already launched a TikTok Shop campaign before I joined, but the account was still effectively in its early stage:

- **Thin purchase history.** Only one prior campaign existed, with limited conversion data - not enough for TikTok's machine learning to identify reliable winning patterns.
- **Unfocused product selection.** A large share of the catalog was being promoted with no clear read on which products actually matched TikTok's shopping behavior.

- **A decision problem, not an ad problem.** The account didn't lack traffic or effort - it lacked the quality of inputs (product fit, creative variety, signal strength) needed for the algorithm to scale confidently.

That reframe - from we need to spend more to we need to feed the algorithm better inputs- set the direction for everything that followed.

Audit & Diagnosis

Before changing anything, I ran a full audit of the account:

- Reviewed prior campaign performance and product-level sales data
- Assessed the existing creative library for coverage and fatigue risk
- Analyzed how customers were engaging with different products
- Benchmarked against TikTok Creative Center trends within Beauty & Skincare-not to copy competitors, but to identify genuine buying patterns around pricing, visual presentation, engagement angles, and consumer behavior

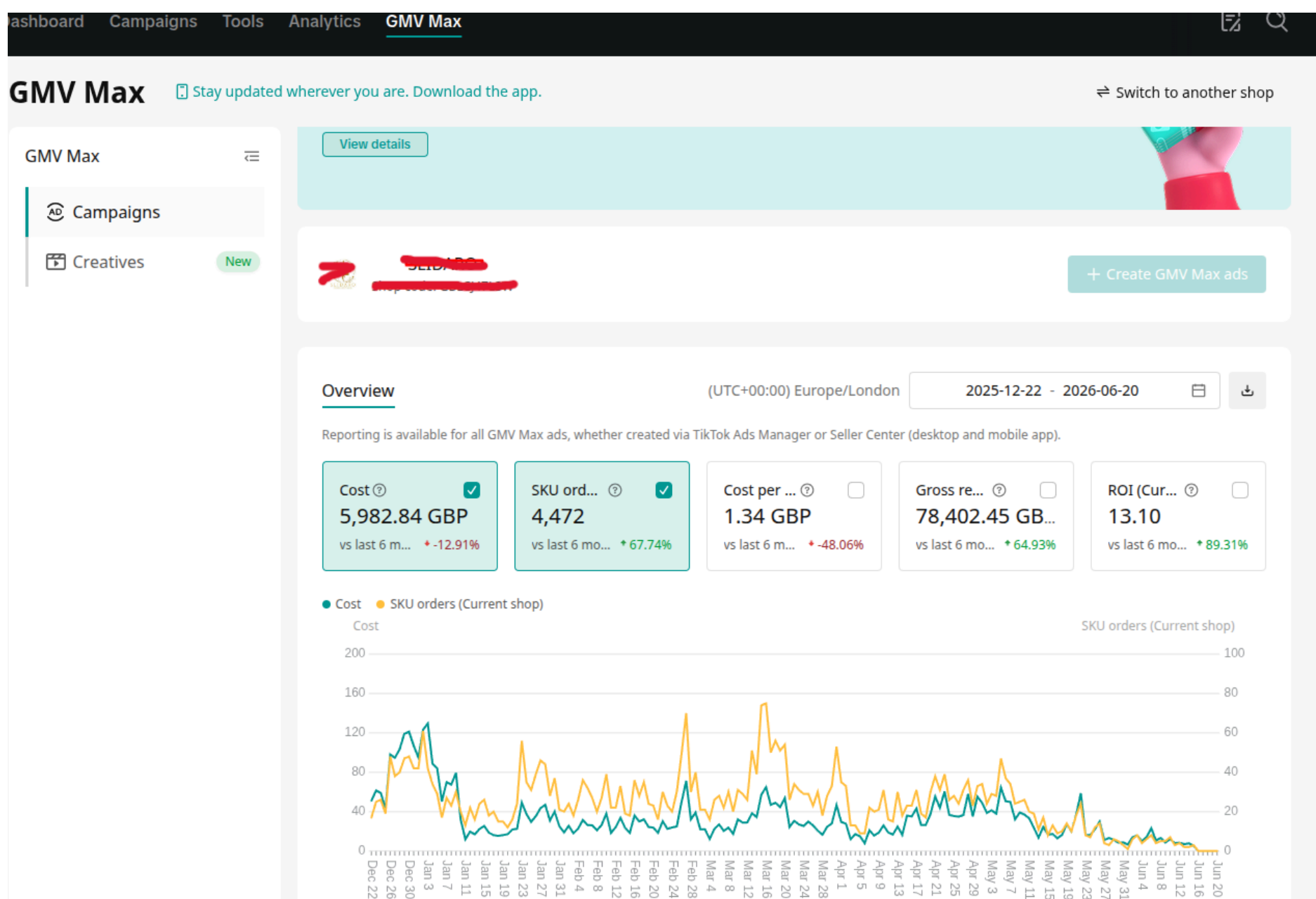
Cross-referencing these insights against the client's catalog showed that only a small subset of products had real scaling potential. That finding became the foundation for the entire strategy: **stop promoting the catalog evenly, and concentrate resources on the products TikTok's shoppers were most likely to buy.**

Strategic Approach

Hypothesis: The account wasn't underperforming because of insufficient traffic - it was underperforming because TikTok wasn't receiving strong enough purchase signals to optimize delivery. Increasing spend on a weak signal base would only scale inefficiency.

Guiding principle: *Give TikTok better products, stronger creatives, and cleaner conversion signals before asking the algorithm to scale.*

Every decision in the campaign - product selection, creative recommendation, budget pacing - was built to reinforce that principle rather than treat it as a one-time fix.



Campaign Structure & GMV Max Setup

TikTok Shop GMV Max is a full-funnel, automated campaign type - rather than manually building and layering audience segments, it consolidates targeting, bidding, and placement decisions under TikTok's algorithm, and optimizes directly toward GMV and order outcomes. This shifts the strategist's leverage point: **the primary lever isn't manual audience targeting, it's the quality of what you feed the algorithm** - product selection, creative diversity, and conversion signal strength.

That's why the rebuild focused on:

- **Product-led targeting.** Prioritizing SKUs with proven demand signals, high impulse-purchase potential, and strong visual appeal, so the algorithm had a stronger foundation to find intent-matched shoppers within the UK beauty & skincare audience.
- **Signal density.** Concentrating spend and creative testing on fewer, better products to generate cleaner, faster purchase data rather than spreading thin, ambiguous signals across the full catalog.
- **Algorithmic trust-building.** Scaling gradually as purchase data accumulated, allowing TikTok's system to progressively refine audience delivery on its own rather than forcing early, aggressive expansion.

Because GMV Max reports success primarily through business outcomes (GMV, ROI, orders, cost per order) rather than traditional funnel metrics like CTR or CPC, the optimization process was built around outcome-level signals – order consistency, cost-per-order trends, and ROI stability – as the true indicators of algorithmic health.

Product Prioritization

Instead of advertising the entire catalog equally, I narrowed focus to the products most likely to convert on TikTok, scored against:

- Historical sales data
- TikTok shopping trends
- Visual appeal
- Problem-solving ability (a core purchase driver in beauty & skincare)
- Impulse-buying potential
- Customer reviews
- Overall market demand

The goal wasn't to advertise *more* products - it was to advertise *better* ones, so every dollar of spend generated a stronger, more informative purchase signal.

Creative Strategy & Ad Formats

The existing creative library was too limited to sustain scaling without hitting fatigue. I expanded it across multiple formats, each serving a distinct role in the funnel:

Format	Purpose
User-Generated Content (UGC)	Builds trust and social proof through authentic, relatable use cases
Creator-style videos	Extends reach and taps into creator-audience trust
Product showcase videos	Demonstrates product benefits and usage clearly
TikTok Live content	Drives real-time engagement and impulse purchases

Creative optimization was treated as an ongoing discipline rather than a one-off production task - every asset was monitored for performance decline and proactively refreshed before fatigue could erode account-level efficiency.

Budget Allocation & Scaling Philosophy

Budget decisions were deliberately conservative and evidence-based. A single strong day was never treated as justification to scale. Before increasing spend on any product or creative, I confirmed:

- Stable ROI over time (not a single spike)
- Consistent order volume
- Healthy, trending cost per order
- Strong, non-fatigued creative performance
- Reliable purchase trends
- Sufficient inventory to support increased demand

Only once these conditions held did budget scale - gradually, and always tied to validated performance rather than momentum or assumption.

Optimization Process

Every decision in the account followed a consistent loop:

Analyze → Validate → Optimize → Scale

In practice, this meant:

- Reallocating budget toward products that consistently delivered profitable orders
- Refreshing creatives at the first signs of fatigue, before performance measurably declined
- Making every optimization call based on observed campaign data - never assumption or guesswork

As stronger products and creatives generated more purchase signals, TikTok's algorithm became progressively more effective at surfacing high-intent shoppers, creating a compounding effect between input quality and delivery efficiency.

Results

KPI	Result
Ad Spend	£5,982.84
Gross Merchandise Value (GMV)	£78,402.45
SKU Orders	4,472
ROI	13.10x
Cost per Order	£1.34
Order Growth	+67.74%
Revenue Growth	+64.93%
Cost per Order Improvement	-48.06%
ROI Improvement	+89.31%

Business Impact

Revenue was the headline outcome, but the more durable win was structural. The account moved from reactive, trial-and-error advertising to a repeatable system:

- A defined product-selection framework that can be reapplied to future SKUs
- A creative production and refresh cadence that prevents fatigue before it hurts performance
- Materially stronger conversion signals feeding TikTok's algorithm
- A disciplined, data-gated scaling process that protects profitability while growing spend

As efficiency improved, customer acquisition became more cost-effective even as revenue continued to climb - the clearest sign that the underlying system, not a single lucky campaign, was driving results.

Key Decisions That Changed Performance

1. **Concentrated the catalog.** Shifted from promoting everything to concentrating budget on products with proven market potential.
2. **Treated creative as a living asset.** Continuously refreshed the creative library instead of relying on a small, static set of videos.
3. **Scaled on evidence, not momentum.** Increased budget only after validating stability across ROI, order volume, and cost per order.
4. **Made data the decision-maker.** Every optimization - product, creative, or budget - was grounded in observed performance rather than assumption.

Lessons & Strategic Takeaways

This project reinforced a core belief about TikTok Shop advertising: **successful campaigns aren't built by increasing budget - they're built by improving the quality of every decision that comes before the budget increase.**

- The right products generate stronger purchase intent.
- The right creatives improve conversion signals.
- Better conversion signals improve machine learning.
- Better machine learning creates sustainable, compounding growth.

When those elements work together, scaling stops being a gamble and becomes a predictable outcome of a well-built system - one that keeps producing results long after the first success.